

Word family: ****baby / babies / babyish / babysit / babysitter / baby-faced****

****Base word:** baby**

****Plural:** babies**

****Related forms:** babyish**

****Useful family extensions:** babysit, babysitter, baby-faced**

****Useful expressions / extensions:** the baby of the family, baby someone, baby animal, baby boom, baby steps**

****Part of speech:** noun (名詞) / adjective-like modifier (名詞作修飾語) / verb (動詞)**

Your sentence:

> “I have known him since he was a ****baby****, of course...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, ****baby**** means ****a very young human child, especially one who has not yet learned to walk or talk fully****.

Leo is now eight, but the speaker has known him since infancy.

****繁體中文 : ** 嬰兒 ; 非常年幼、仍處於人生最早期階段的小孩****

****中文翻譯 : ****

> “I have known him since he was a baby.”

「我從他還是****嬰兒****的時候就認識他了。」

Here:

****baby = 嬰兒 / 非常年幼的小孩****

1. ****baby = very young child (嬰兒) — 嬰兒 ; 小寶寶****

This is the exact sense in your passage.

Practice 1 — Original

> “I have known him since he was a ****baby****.”

「我從他還是****嬰兒****的時候就認識他了。」

Practice 2

> “The ****baby**** is sleeping.”

「那個****嬰兒****正在睡覺。」

Practice 3

> “She is holding a six-month-old ****baby****.”

「她抱著一個六個月大的****嬰兒****。」

****baby** = 非常年幼的人類小孩，尤其指尚未能完全獨立走路或說話的嬰幼兒******

2. ****baby** = very young animal (幼獸 / 小動物) — 幼小動物******

A common extension.

Practice 4

> “The zoo has a new ****baby elephant****.”

「動物園有一隻新出生的****小象****。」

Practice 5

> “We saw several ****baby birds**** in the nest.”

「我們在巢裡看到幾隻****幼鳥****。」

****baby + animal** = 年齡非常小、尚未完全長成的動物******

This is not literally “嬰兒” in Chinese; translation depends on the animal.

3. ****baby** = youngest member of a family/group (最年幼的人) — 家中 / 群體中最小的一個******

A distinct figurative/person-label use.

Practice 6

> “He is the ****baby of the family****.”

「他是家裡****最年幼的一個****。」

Practice 7

> “Even though she is twenty, everyone still treats her as the ****baby**** of the family.”

「即使她已經二十歲，大家仍然把她當成家裡****最小的那個****。」

****the baby of the family = 家庭中年齡最小的成員，不一定真的是嬰兒****

4. ****baby = affectionate term of address (親暱稱呼) — 寶貝；親愛的****

A common modern use.

Practice 8

> “Come here, ****baby****.”

「過來吧，****寶貝****。」

Practice 9

> “Good night, ****baby****.”

「晚安，****親愛的 / 寶貝****。」

****baby = 對伴侶、小孩或非常親密的人使用的親暱稱呼****

Register:

> informal / affectionate

Context matters greatly.

5. ****baby = something especially cherished (珍愛之物 / 心血) — 心血；特別珍視的事物****

A genuine figurative sense.

Practice 10

> “This project is her ****baby****.”

「這個項目是她的****心血 / 她非常珍視的項目****。」

Practice 11

> “He built the company from nothing, so it is really his **baby**.”

「他白手興家建立這間公司，所以它真的像是他的**心血結晶**。」

someone's baby = 某人親手建立、特別投入並非常珍視的事物 / 項目

This does **not** refer to an actual child.

6. **baby** — verb = treat someone like a baby (過度照顧 / 嬌縱) — 把.....當小孩般照顧

Now **baby** functions as a verb.

Practice 12

> “Stop **babying** him.”

「不要再把他**當小孩一樣過度照顧**。」

Practice 13

> “His parents tend to **baby** him too much.”

「他的父母往往對他**過度保護 / 過分呵護**。」

baby someone = 把某人當作比實際更弱小或更不能自理的人來過度照顧 / 保護

This can carry criticism.

7. **baby** — verb = handle very gently (小心呵護) — 小心對待；特別呵護

A related extension.

Practice 14

> “He **babies** his old car.”

「他對那部舊車**小心呵護得不得了**。」

Practice 15

> “She ****babied**** the injured knee for several weeks.”

「她幾個星期都對受傷的膝蓋****特別小心保護****。」

****baby something** = 對某物 / 身體部位異常小心地保護、使用或照顧******

This grows from the idea of treating something as delicately as a baby.

8. ****babyish** = childish / immature (幼稚的) — 像嬰兒的 ; 幼稚的******

A useful adjective.

Practice 16

> “That voice sounds a little ****babyish****.”

「那把聲音聽起來有點****像嬰兒 / 很孩子氣****。」

Practice 17

> “He sometimes behaves in a ****babyish**** way when he does not get what he wants.”

「當他得不到想要的東西時，有時會表現得很****幼稚****。」

****babyish** = 像嬰兒一樣，或顯得不成熟、幼稚的******

Often mildly negative when used about older children/adults.

9. ****baby-faced** = looking unusually young (娃娃臉的) — 長得很年輕 ; 娃娃臉的******

A useful compound.

Practice 18

> “He is very ****baby-faced****.”

「他長得很****娃娃臉 / 顯得很年輕****。」

Practice 19

> “The actor still looks ****baby-faced**** in his thirties.”

「那位演員三十多歲仍然看起來很**年輕、很娃娃臉**。」

****baby-faced = 臉部特徵令人看起來比實際年齡更年輕****

10. ****babysit = take care of a child temporarily (臨時照顧小孩) — 幫忙照顧小孩****

A major lexical-family extension.

Practice 20

> “I sometimes ****babysit**** my cousin’s son.”

「我有時會幫忙****照顧表姐的兒子****。」

Practice 21

> “Can you ****babysit**** tonight?”

「你今晚可以幫忙****照顧小朋友****嗎？」

****babysit = 在父母 / 主要照顧者不在時，暫時照顧小孩****

This is especially relevant to your passage because the speaker often helped look after Leo.

11. ****babysitter = person who temporarily cares for children (臨時保母) — 保母；臨時照顧小孩的人****

Practice 22

> “They hired a ****babysitter**** for the evening.”

「他們晚上請了一位****臨時保母****。」

Practice 23

> “The ****babysitter**** stayed until midnight.”

「那位****保母****留到午夜。」

****babysitter = 在父母 / 主要照顧者暫時不在時負責照顧孩子的人****

12. ****baby boom (嬰兒潮) — 出生率突然大幅上升的時期****

A common historical/social compound.

Practice 24

> “The country experienced a ****baby boom**** after the war.”

「戰後該國出現了****嬰兒潮****。」

Practice 25

> “The ****baby boom**** increased demand for schools.”

「****嬰兒潮****令學校需求增加。」

****baby boom = 某段時期內出生嬰兒數量突然明顯增加的現象****

13. ****baby boomer (嬰兒潮世代的人) — 嬰兒潮世代****

Practice 26

> “Many ****baby boomers**** are now retired.”

「很多****嬰兒潮世代人士****現在已經退休。」

Practice 27

> “The survey compared millennials with ****baby boomers****.”

「調查比較了千禧世代和****嬰兒潮世代****。」

****baby boomer = 出生於某次主要嬰兒潮期間的人，尤其常指二戰後出生的一代****

14. ****baby steps (小步前進) — 小步驟；循序漸進****

A very common figurative expression.

Practice 28

> “We are making progress in ****baby steps****.”

「我們正以****很小的步驟逐步前進****。」

Practice 29

> “Take ****baby steps**** instead of trying to change everything at once.”

「不要一次改變所有事情，先用****小步驟慢慢來****。」

****baby steps = 很小、容易處理的步驟，用來逐漸取得進展****

The figurative idea comes from a baby learning to walk.

15. ****baby teeth (乳齒) — 乳牙****

Practice 30

> “Children eventually lose their ****baby teeth****.”

「孩子最終會換掉他們的****乳牙****。」

Practice 31

> “One of his ****baby teeth**** has fallen out.”

「他有一隻****乳牙****掉了。」

****baby teeth = 兒童最早長出的第一套牙齒，之後會被恆齒取代****

16. ****baby food (嬰兒食品) — 嬰兒食物****

Practice 32

> “They bought some ****baby food****.”

「他們買了一些****嬰兒食品****。」

Practice 33

> “The child has started eating solid ****baby food****.”

「那個小孩開始吃固體****嬰兒食品****。」

****baby food** = 特別為嬰幼兒製作、容易吞食或消化的食物******

Important distinction: **baby vs child**

**baby**

= very young child, especially in infancy.

**child**

= broader category covering young humans beyond infancy.

So:

> every baby is a child

but:

> not every child is a baby.

In your passage, Leo is now a ****child****, but the speaker knew him when he was a ****baby****.

Important distinction: **baby vs infant**

**baby**

is the ordinary everyday word.

**infant**

is more formal and often used in:

* medicine

* law

* official contexts

> “a baby”

sounds warmer and more natural in ordinary conversation.

> “an infant”

sounds more technical/formal.

Important distinction: **baby vs toddler**

baby

generally refers to the earliest stage.

toddler

specifically means:

> a very young child who has begun walking but is still very young.

So:

> newborn → baby → toddler → child

is a useful rough developmental sequence.

Important distinction: **baby = infant vs baby = youngest member**

Compare:

> “She has a baby.”

= 她有一個嬰兒。

versus:

> “She is the baby of the family.”

= 她是家裡年紀最小的一個。

The second person could even be an adult.

Important distinction: **baby = child vs baby = term of affection**

Literal:

> “The baby is crying.”

= 嬰兒在哭。

Affectionate:

> “I missed you, baby.”

= 親愛的，我很想你。

The affectionate meaning depends heavily on relationship and tone.

Important distinction: ****baby someone vs care for someone****

****care for someone****

= look after or support them appropriately.

****baby someone****

= treat them as if they were much less capable than they really are.

So ****baby**** often implies:

> too much protection / not enough independence.

Important distinction: ****baby someone vs spoil someone****

These overlap but are not identical.

****baby someone****

= overprotect or treat them as incapable.

****spoil someone****

= give them too much of what they want, often making them demanding.

A child can be babied without necessarily being spoiled.

Important distinction: ****babyish vs childish****

****babyish****

strongly suggests behaviour, appearance, or sound resembling a baby.

****childish****

means immature in a way associated with children generally.

- > babyish voice
- > childish argument

So ****babyish**** often sounds even younger.

Important distinction: ****babyish vs childlike****

****babyish****

often negative:

- > immature / too young-seeming

****childlike****

often positive or neutral:

- > innocent, trusting, curious

So:

- > childlike wonder

is positive.

- > babyish behaviour

is often critical.

Important distinction: ****baby-faced vs young****

young

describes actual age.

baby-faced

describes appearance.

Someone can be:

> forty years old but baby-faced.

Important distinction: **babysit vs look after**

babysit

specifically refers to temporary childcare.

look after

is much broader.

You can look after:

- * children
- * elderly people
- * pets
- * property

So in your passage:

> “I often helped look after him”

could sometimes be paraphrased as:

> “I often helped babysit him”

but **look after** is broader and does not necessarily imply the parents were absent.

Important distinction: **baby steps — literal vs figurative**

Literal:

> a baby taking tiny first steps.

Figurative:

> very small, gradual stages of progress.

> “Let’s take baby steps.”

= 我們一步一步慢慢來。

This is now a well-established idiomatic extension.

Family-extension note

For this project, **baby** is a good **moderate polysemy** case.

The main genuine branches are:

- * **baby — human infant**
- * **baby — young animal**
- * **baby — youngest member**
- * **baby — affectionate address**
- * **baby — cherished project/thing**
- * **baby — verb: overprotect**
- * **baby — verb: handle very gently**

Then the useful family/compound sweep adds:

- * **babyish**
- * **baby-faced**
- * **babysit**
- * **babysitter**
- * **baby boom**
- * **baby boomer**
- * **baby steps**
- * **baby teeth**
- * **baby food**

These should be kept clearly labelled as family extensions or fixed compounds rather than counted as additional bare-word meanings. That follows the manual’s rule to expand useful family material while preserving lexical identity accurately.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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baby — human child	非常年幼、仍處於人生最早期階段的小孩；嬰兒
baby — young animal	尚未完全長成的幼小動物
the baby of the family	家庭 / 群體中年齡最小的成員
baby — affectionate address	對伴侶、小孩或親密的人使用的親暱稱呼；寶貝
someone's baby	某人親手建立、非常投入並特別珍視的事物 / 項目
baby someone	把某人當成比實際更弱小或更不能自理的人來過度照顧
baby something	對某物 / 身體部位非常小心地呵護或使用
babyish	像嬰兒一樣；顯得幼稚、不成熟的
baby-faced	臉部特徵令人看起來比實際年齡更年輕的
babysit	在父母 / 主要照顧者不在時暫時照顧小孩
babysitter	暫時負責照顧孩子的人
baby boom	某段時期內出生嬰兒數量突然大幅增加的現象
baby boomer	出生於主要嬰兒潮時期的一代人
baby steps	很小、容易處理、用來逐步取得進展的步驟
baby teeth	兒童最早長出的第一套牙齒；乳牙
baby food	特別為嬰幼兒製作的食物

For your original sentence

> “I have known him since he was a ****baby****, of course...”

The exact meaning is:

****baby = 非常年幼的人類小孩；嬰兒****

Therefore:

> ****since he was a baby****

= ****「從他還是嬰兒的時候開始」****

The sentence simply traces the relationship back to Leo's earliest stage of life.

So this is ****not****:

* ****the baby of the family**** = 家中年紀最小的人

* ****baby!**** = 寶貝 / 親愛的

* ****this project is my baby**** = 我的心血

* ****baby him**** = 過度保護他

It is the straightforward **human-infant sense**.